

Delta Force
Soldiers jump from a moving Humvee during a training exercise. Delta Force was created specifically for the purpose of counter-terrorism and national interventions operations, and forms the core of the unit hunting Osama Bin Laden. The US equivalent of the British SAS, Delta Force requires recruits to undergo a punishing selection course.

Apart from the use of helicopters for transport and fire support, nothing radically distinguished the combat experience of the infantryman in these conflicts from that of World War II.

FALL OF EMPIRES

The conflict in Vietnam was not only a limited war fought within the context of the Cold War, but also a war of national liberation fought as part of a worldwide process of decolonization. The European imperial powers, who had carved up much of Africa and Asia between them in the 1800s, were weakened financially, militarily, and psychologically by World War II. In the postwar era Europeans faced independence movements in their colonies which, in places, resorted to arms. In Latin America, liberation movements emerged that also saw themselves as essentially part of the anti-colonial movement, with the US cast as the imperial power.

The natural mode of combat for fighters taking on the forces of a colonial state was guerrilla warfare. Guerrillas were inspired by the example of Mao Zedong's victory in the Chinese Civil War in 1949, achieved by a graduated campaign building up from small-scale raids by rural-based guerrillas to eventual large-scale conventional warfare. The pattern was repeated in Vietnam in the 1960s and 1970s, when the US and the South Vietnamese government were defeated in a war that was started by Viet Cong guerrillas wearing rubber sandals and ended by soldiers of the North Vietnamese Army driving tanks.

On the whole, however, guerrilla forces remained relatively small, lightly equipped groups. Where they succeeded in taking power, they did so because their opponent's will to resist collapsed. Thus the triumph of Fidel Castro in Cuba in 1959 was dependent on the political breakdown of the Cuban government, rather than the military strength of Castro's guerrillas. But although revolutionary guerrilla movements often failed, or had success fall into their laps, the guerrilla fighter undoubtedly became one of the most widely admired warrior figures of modern times, glamorized in the heroic image of Ernesto "Che" Guevara.

CONVENTIONAL WAR

The colonial era was over by the end of the 1970s, but with no discernable reduction in the incidence of war. In the 1980s the US became a promoter of guerrilla war, backing irregular forces against the Soviet Union in Afghanistan, and against left-wing governments in Nicaragua, Angola, and Mozambique. At the same time, Western powers became increasingly interested in rapid reaction forces, ready for overseas intervention whenever required. The era of mass conscript armies seemed to be receding, with increasing reliance on well-trained professional soldiers. Special forces grew in importance both for use in conventional warfare and for countering guerrilla and other irregular forces.

Special forces found another use in countering the growth of international terrorism. Terrorist tactics such as assassination and bombings were always present as an adjunct of guerrilla warfare, but from the late 1960s onward terrorism developed an independent existence as the weapon of various groups opposed to the US-led capitalist world. Special forces trained for scenarios like airliner hijackings and hostage-taking, as strategists pondered how to counter an enemy operating almost below the military horizon. The use of conventional military force in a war on terrorism – as declared by President Bush in 2001 – has been compared to using a pistol against a swarm of bees.

UNSTABLE WORLD

Much terrorist activity originated in the Middle East, a focus for war both before and after the ending of the Cold War in the late 1980s. Israel was founded and sustained by military prowess in a series of wars with its Arab neighbours, while Saddam Hussein's rule in Iraq triggered a succession of conflicts – with Iran, Iraq's Kurdish population, a UN coalition after the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, and finally with a US and British invasion force in 2003. The disintegration of Iraq after Saddam's fall made it likely to join the many areas of the world where war had become a permanent state of affairs – Afghanistan, Congo, Colombia, and Sudan were other examples. The world was awash with weaponry and men were as ready to fight as they ever had been, for power, for profit, for ideals, or out of hatred and fear.





